

A **nuclear war** would be **catastrophic**; no sane person would launch a **nuclear attack**.

If **nuclear weapons** can never be used, they do not serve as a **deterrent** and therefore **have no purpose**.

The world should **stop the arms race** and **disarm**.

Banning testing of nuclear weapons is the first step toward nuclear disarmament.

pretexts for spying by the West. In June 1963, President Kennedy made an impassioned plea for “a treaty to outlaw nuclear tests [and] check the spiraling arms race.”

The first test ban

In July 1963, W. Averell Harriman, former US ambassador to the USSR, and Andrei Gromyko, Soviet foreign minister, resumed negotiations in Moscow. After 10 days, they initialed a draft treaty, hoping the other three nuclear powers of the time (the UK, France, and China) would join, but only the UK signed along with the US and USSR.

The Partial Nuclear Test Ban Treaty (PTBT) banned nuclear weapons tests in the atmosphere, in outer space, and underwater but permitted underground testing. The treaty did nothing to cut

stockpiles of nuclear weapons, halt production, or limit their use, but it was a major step forward.

Within 3 months, a total of 100 governments had signed up, although France and China stayed out. Since then, 25 more nations have joined. Under the treaty, the US, UK, and USSR can veto treaty amendments. Also, a majority, including all three original parties, must approve any amendment.

Nonproliferation

Efforts to limit the spread of nuclear weapons beyond the original five nuclear powers began in the 1960s, alongside the PTBT. In 1961, the UN unanimously passed Ireland's resolution to ban nuclear powers from giving the technology to other states. Sweden proposed also that non-nuclear countries pledge not to

A nuclear war cannot be won and must never be fought.

Ronald Reagan
40th US president (1981–1989),
State of the Union address, 1984

make or host nuclear weapons; the proposal had good support, but many states abstained, including the US. The Irish and Swedish proposals sought to create a regime that everyone could adhere to, and it came to fruition in the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT) of 1968.

In the NPT, non-nuclear-armed nations agreed never to acquire or develop nuclear weapons, while nuclear states agreed to eliminate their nuclear arsenals over time and share technology for nuclear energy.

Comprehensive ban

In 1977, work began on a treaty to end nuclear testing. Progress was slow, partly because American weapons developers felt testing was vital to keep nuclear weapons up to date; under pressure from them, US President Ronald Reagan halted negotiations in 1982. The Soviets' 1979–1989 occupation of Afghanistan also soured relations with the US.

In 1991, Soviet general secretary Mikhail Gorbachev announced that the USSR would unilaterally stop its nuclear weapons testing. The US Congress responded warmly, urging that negotiations quickly reopen. Even so, discussions were hampered